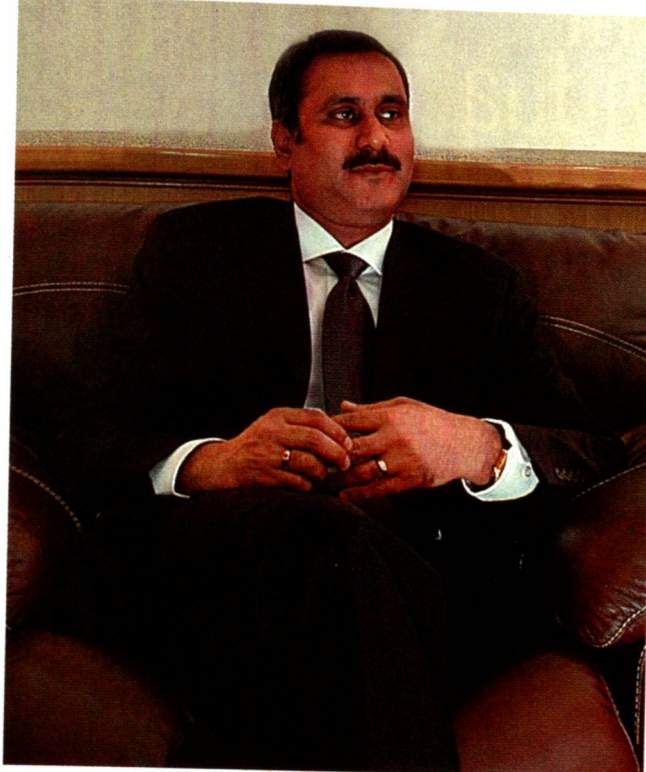




Anbumani Ramadoss

DOCTOR NO

A for AIIMS, A for Anbumani. "Stemming the rot" was his claim to fame. But going by the tightrope he is now walking between the hammer of law and the anvil of public opinion, the All India Institute of Medical Sciences may just turn out to be his nemesis.

When he took over the health portfolio, the prime minister's salt-and-pepper Cabinet didn't have anyone like him: a sharply-dressed, laptop-toting medic, who spoke English without a trace of Tamil and had a stint at the London School of Economics. If he was hailed as the "dynamic, young face of politics", he promised a new dispensation: "Today politics stinks. It needs to be cleansed." That single-minded pursuit is the key to creativity in his pillbox. Be it in untarnishing his name or purging the nation's lungs of tobacco fumes.

The year 2007 saw him treading into waters where ministers ought not to venture. Will his impeccable political pedigree save the prince of the most backward Vanniyaars? He has met his match in the AIIMS director. Both are medics, both head questionable authority, both are territorial, both carry the big stick of political endorsement and caste cards. Will it be checkmate for him this time?

by Damayanti Datta

THE YEAR 2007 saw Ramadoss treading into waters where ministers ought not to venture. He has met his match in the AIIMS director.

Rajnikanth

KOLLYWOOD KING

His 154th film, *Sivaji*, sailed past the Rs 100-crore mark this year to become the top grossing non-Hindi film of all times, but it was the electrifying effect it had on audiences—frenzied stampedes from Madurai to Malaysia—that makes a Rajnikanth film unlike any other Indian movie star's. But then, Rajnikanth, who transformed, almost Clark-Kent like, from the short, bald and swarthy into a mop-maned fighting-singing-dancing onscreen Superman, is no ordinary star. In his two-decade plus reign, his movies have transcended celluloid to become the sociological phenomena so stereotypical of Dravidian cinema. It comes easily for a man who has morphed from a bus conductor to the country's highest paid star who takes home a Rs 20-crore cheque per movie. His latest releases see him assimilating the legacy of MGR. The question is where does he go from here?

by Sandeep Unnithan

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